Russophobia. For, Curzon did not necessarily hate Russia as much as he feared it. Indeed, in some ways Curzon held a certain amount of respect for Russia. In his study of the Trans-Caspian railway he did not hesitate to applaud the technical achievements of the Russian engineers in having completed the task in such difficult desert terrain.[92] There was also an amount of understanding as to why, given its geographical position, Russia did appear compelled to expand into Central Asia.[93] Indeed, one could argue that it was just this acceptance of Russia's needs and its capabilities that made Curzon ardently fearful of the threat that country posed to Britain; for it would seem that the Russian march through to the borders of India was somehow inevitable. Rather than blaming Russia for what it was in its nature to do, Curzon instead tended to criticise the various British governments for allowing its rival to act this way. If Britain was to be gullible and complacent, 'it had therefore no right to complain of Russia's advance'.[94]

Furthermore, Curzon was only too aware that a full-scale military invasion was not necessary for Russia to still create trouble for the British Empire. That the British in India were but 'a little foam on an unfathomable and dark ocean' was something Curzon understood entirely.[95] Without the appearance that the empire was indestructibly powerful, stable, confident and wealthy, Britain's position would be highly vulnerable. For Curzon, to allow Russia to damage British prestige was akin to allowing the destruction of the empire. Hence, his Great Game call to arms:

> Whatever be Russia's designs upon India, whether they be serious and inimical or imaginary and fantastic, I hold that the first duty of English statesmen is to render any hostile intentions futile, to see that our own position is secure and our frontier impregnable, and so to guard what is without a doubt the noblest trophy of British genius.[96]

Throughout his public career, Curzon would be a vocal opponent of any British government policy that appeared to concede too much to Russia's imperial ambitions. For, always, he had in mind not so much the reality of